It had the usual loud characters, like Swanny and Matty Prior, though they were capable of sober reflection. We drew on the emotional energy of Freddie Flintoff as he played through the pain of a chronic knee problem after announcing his impending retirement before the second Test, at Lord's.

There was a point of difference, though. Intriguingly, and perhaps decisively, the group that went on to become number one consisted mainly of introverted characters. That is extremely unusual in an elite male sports team. Strauss set a measured tone as captain. Senior players, key achievers like Jimmy Anderson, Stuart Broad, Ian Bell, Paul Collingwood, myself and, latterly, Jonathan Trott were inclined to withdraw into ourselves.

Critically, we were alive to the challenges of character. We each knew our default mechanism under pressure was to keep our own counsel and concentrate on making the very best of ourselves. If those instincts were unchecked, we would hesitate to contribute in team meetings, preferring to internalize information rather than share deeper thoughts. When things were tough, we consciously forced ourselves to speak up, because that was what the side needed.

This was where the paradox of Kevin Pietersen became apparent. He applied himself superbly, following his demotion, before being forced to withdraw from the second Test, and the series, after surgery on his right Achilles tendon. He had put himself on the line when the injury flared up in the spring, but a regime of rest and pain-killing injections had only short-term success.

He came across to me as a fusion of two different personalities. The introvert – let's call him Kevin – is driven, a deep thinker about the technicalities of his batting and the intricacies of the game. The extrovert – the alter ego we will refer to as KP – is a colourful, compelling character, thrilling in his intensity and creativity.

I'm no psychologist, but any captain learns to read people. My hunch is his insecurity flicked the switch and made him extroverted almost to command. If he felt under threat, he would be the peacock strutting around, showing his multicoloured tail feathers. He probably needed that exhibitionist streak in order to bat at his best.

That's no criticism, by the way. We should celebrate our differences, since in psychological terms we are all colours of the rainbow. I've already mentioned I was defined a cool blue, fond of structure, discipline and